

# Cover Letter

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Dear Editor,

I am pleased to submit my manuscript, "Stolen Strata: Quantifying the Anthropogenic Erasure of Kashmir's Karewa Terraces and Its Threat to the Saffron Economy," for consideration as a Research Article in Applied Geography.

This study delineates 201 karewa terraces in Kashmir's Pampore-Pulwama-Budgam belt using a fully scripted, algorithmic pipeline (Topographic Position Index and slope thresholds on Copernicus DEM data), and tracks bare-earth land-cover change across four time points from 1994 to 2025 using Landsat and Sentinel-2 imagery. It finds that terrace degradation is recent and accelerating (essentially flat until 2015, then more than tripling by 2025), statistically associated with proximity to roads and settlements, and concentrated on a saffron-growing economy that this study values in monetary terms using official state yield and price data. It also documents that no current legislation in Jammu & Kashmir protects karewa land from excavation. I believe this combination of geomorphological quantification, statistical infrastructure-proximity testing, economic valuation, and policy context fits Applied Geography's scope in applying geospatial methods to a concrete, actionable land-use problem.

The manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration at any other journal. All data sources are cited and, where restrictions allow, the processing code and processed data will be made available in a public repository upon acceptance. I declare no competing interests, and further declarations (ethics, funding, data availability, CRediT authorship, and generative-AI use) are included in the manuscript and in the accompanying separate files as required.

Thank you for considering this manuscript. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

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